

generally fairly secretive about these things, it is impossible to pretend to know who's doing what or what works best.

If you are expecting a clear, detailed, and exhaustive survey of these things in this book, you will be disappointed. You could write a tome on each one. And still have enough left over for a sequel.

Also, please, keep in mind who is writing to you. The elder Bonner went to Georgetown University's Law Center in the 1970s. He never practiced law and has forgotten almost everything he learned. We are deliberately not trying to write a thorough, up-to-date guide to estate planning or tax avoidance. Nor are we trying to provide precise or practical advice.

Why?

Because we don't want you to make any important decisions based on this book alone. Setting up your own hard structures is much too complicated and too fraught with traps. This chapter simply lays out what we consider the main ideas involved, as understood by us, nonprofessionals with little patience for the details of estate planning or taxes. Our goal is merely to show you the kind of things you're going to have to deal with and to tell you a bit about our experience with them.

To those general warnings, we add two more:

First, you know what they say about the man who represents himself in a court case? He has a "fool for a lawyer." It's true of estate planning, too. If you try to do it yourself, your estate planner will be an idiot.

Second, we also want to alert you to the fact that there are, according to the old legal expression, many ways to skin this cat. We do not claim to be aware of all of them. And our approach may be very particular to us and our situation.

A WILL AND AN ESTATE PLAN

A colleague came up to me and said, "Why do you bother with all that complicated tax avoidance stuff? You can achieve the same thing with insurance."

This was not the first time we had heard about the insurance angle. The gist of it, as we understand it, is that certain life insurance payouts are not